

AIRBORNE ASSAULT

OPERATION MARKET GARDEN

Launched in September 1944, Operation Market Garden was the largest airborne assault to date, aimed at seizing tactical objectives in the Netherlands. It might have shortened the war; but its successes and eventual failure showed both the strengths and weaknesses of airborne forces.

In August 1944, British and American airborne troops were placed under unified command as the First Allied Airborne Army. General Bernard Montgomery of the British Army planned to use this force to open a path through the German-occupied Netherlands and into northern Germany. Airborne troops, both parachute and glider infantry, were to seize and hold a series of bridges and canals to allow the British 30th Corps, advancing from the Allied front line, to move towards the German border.

The scale of the airborne operation was unprecedented. Taking off from England on 17 September, the first wave involved over 20,000 troops packed into more than 1,500 transport aircraft and 500 gliders. Allied air supremacy allowed this aerial armada to fly to its target areas in daylight, dropping parachutists and their equipment with varied accuracy. The gliders, towed by "tug" aircraft, also mostly landed safely. But once on the ground, the airborne forces were in a risky position. Although some heavy equipment was landed with them, they were unsupported infantry deep inside hostile territory. Once the enemy recovered from the surprise of the initial assault, the lightly armed troops would have to resist counterattacks until the arrival of the British corps' tanks and artillery.

US 101st Airborne Division landed near Eindhoven, closest to the Allied front line. They quickly took four of the five bridges assigned to them and were joined by the advancing British armoured forces on 18 September. US 82nd Airborne were assigned responsibility for seizing crossings of the Maas and Waal Rivers. Engaged

in heavy fighting, they succeeded in repelling German counterattacks but failed to take the vital bridge at Nijmegen; meanwhile a second round of airdrops and glider landings that should have brought reinforcements was delayed in poor weather. The British corps successfully made contact with 82nd Airborne on 19 September, but the bridge was not taken until the next day, after a high-casualty river crossing by troops in rowing boats.

BEST-LAID PLANS

These delays placed Britain's First Airborne Division, attempting to take the final bridge over the Rhine at Arnhem, in a desperate situation. The paratroops had landed too far from their target; with radio and navigation problems, they lost coherence in the advance towards Arnhem, and only one battalion reached the bridge. German counterattacks, meanwhile, were ferocious. The presence of two SS panzer divisions in the area had been reported by intelligence sources before the operation, but the information had been ignored: now, infantry divisions with only light artillery support found themselves fighting for their lives against German tanks.

The arrival of the Polish Parachute Brigade to reinforce the British was delayed until 21 September, and even then they were dropped in the wrong place. After heroic resistance, the battalion at the bridge surrendered, on the same day. On 25 September, efforts turned to evacuating surviving soldiers across the Rhine. In total 2,398 were saved, but 1,485 had been killed and 6,414 taken prisoner. The operation had failed.

